Book 2

# What To Actually Do With It

## A creative playbook

Book 3 tells you what to type. This one argues for what is worth trying. The workflows here are chosen because delegating them changes what you would realistically attempt — not merely how quickly you would do something you were going to do anyway.

**In this book**

- 24 worked ideas across 6 themes
- Beating the blank page, and why disposability is the point
- Delegating the boring half of production
- Learning theory with your own project as the worked example
- Things that are musically interesting but impractical by hand
- Closed loops: change it, measure it, adjust

Every idea names the actions that carry it, so you can cross-reference Book 5 for the detail.

A note on how to read this: each idea has a rough prompt attached, but they are starting points rather than incantations. Genius responds to intent, so adapt the wording to your project. The actions listed underneath are what the request is expected to reach for.

# Beating the blank page

The most expensive moment in music production is the one before anything exists. Genius is unusually good here because it costs you nothing to throw away.

## Ten starts before breakfast

Ask for ten completely different 4-bar loops — different tempo, different key, different genre — each in its own scene. Then delete nine. The value isn't in the generation, it's in discovering which one you reach for without thinking.

> ***Try:*** *"Build me ten 4-bar starting points in ten scenes. Vary the tempo, key and style widely. Name each scene after its genre." Then listen once through and keep whichever one you're still humming.*

**Uses:** `live_create_scene` · `live_create_track` · `live_write_notes` · `live_update_set`

## The constraint generator

Ask for something deliberately restrictive — five notes only, one chord, no kick drum, everything in 7/8. Constraints are the oldest trick for forcing originality, and Genius will follow one rigidly where you'd cheat.

> ***Try:*** *"Write me a full 8-bar idea using only five different pitches, ever, across all tracks." Then try to finish it without breaking the rule.*

**Uses:** `live_write_notes` · `live_create_chord_progression` · `live_update_set`

## Steal from yourself

Point it at a folder of unfinished projects and have it rank them by how close to done they are. The one you abandoned eighteen months ago is often two hours from finished — you just can't remember which one that is.

> ***Try:*** *"Scan every .als in this folder, rank them by how finished they are, and tell me which three are worth reopening." Ableton doesn't even need to be running.*

**Uses:** `als_summary` · `als_find_unfinished` · `als_list_tracks`

## Genre transplant

Take a loop you already have and ask for it rebuilt in a completely different style — same chords, drum'n'bass tempo; same melody, as a bossa nova. Familiar material in unfamiliar clothes is a reliable way to hear it fresh.

> ***Try:*** *"Read the chords in track 3, then rebuild that progression at 174 BPM with a breakbeat feel in scene 4."*

**Uses:** `live_read_clip` · `live_detect_key` · `live_create_chord_progression` · `live_create_scene`

# Delegating the tedious half

Every producer has a list of jobs that are trivially easy and unbearably boring. This is the least glamorous use of Genius and probably the highest value.

### Session hygiene on demand

Default track names, unlabelled clips, no colour coding, twelve things soloed from three days ago. Ten minutes of tidying you'll never voluntarily do.

> ***Try:*** *"Rename every default-named track based on what's actually on it, colour-code by instrument family, and unsolo everything."*

**Uses:** `live_read_set` · `live_update_track` · `live_batch_tracks`

### Arrangement scaffolding

Laying out a 64-bar structure by dragging clips is pure mechanical labour. Describe the structure in one sentence and go make coffee.

> ***Try:*** *"8-bar intro, 16 verse, 16 chorus, 8 breakdown, 16 outro. Build it from my session clips and add locators for each section."*

**Uses:** `live_duplicate_to_arrangement` · `live_update_set` · `live_read_arrangement_length`

### Variation farming

You need eight subtly different hi-hat patterns. Generating them by hand is twenty minutes; asking for them is twenty seconds and they'll be more different from each other than yours would have been.

> ***Try:*** *"Give me eight hat variations in slots 1-8 on track 2, each a different Euclidean pattern, from sparse to busy."*

**Uses:** `live_generate_euclidean` · `live_create_drum_pattern`

### The pre-mix checklist

Before you start mixing, someone should check for the obvious problems. That someone has historically been nobody.

> ***Try:*** *"Audit my mix: flag low-end clashes, anything clipping, missing limiter, lopsided panning. Just the list, don't fix anything yet."*

**Uses:** `live_analyze_mix` · `live_read_set` · `live_read_meter`

## Learning while you work

The knowledge base is local and the Set is right there, which makes it possible to ask a theory question and immediately hear the answer in your own project.

### Explain, then demonstrate

The single best pattern for learning anything musical. Don't just ask what negative harmony is — ask for it applied to the chords already in your Set.

> ***Try:*** *"Explain modal interchange, then take my progression in track 3 and show me three borrowed-chord variations in slots 2, 3 and 4."*

**Uses:** `library_db_search` · `live_read_clip` · `live_create_chord_progression`

### Reverse-engineer your own instincts

Ask it to analyse something you wrote by feel and tell you what you actually did. Finding out your favourite progression is a deceptive cadence you've been using unconsciously for years is genuinely useful.

> ***Try:*** *"Detect the key of track 3, analyse the progression, and tell me what I've done in theory terms and why it works."*

**Uses:** `live_detect_key` · `live_read_clip` · `library_db_search`

### Read the manual without reading the manual

The official Ableton manual and roughly 140 third-party plugin manuals are sitting in your Training Docs folder. Ask the specific question instead of scrolling a PDF.

> ***Try:*** *"How do I set up a custom mode on my Launchkey? Check the actual Novation manual."*

**Uses:** `library_search` · `library_read` · `library_db_search`

### Deliberate practice generator

Ask for exercises targeted at a specific weakness, written into your Set as real MIDI you can play along with.

> ***Try:*** *"I'm weak on jazz voicings. Write me five ii-V-I exercises in different keys, one per scene, with rootless voicings."*

**Uses:** `live_generate_chords` · `live_create_scene` · `library_db_search`

## Things that are impractical by hand

Some ideas are musically interesting but too fiddly to be worth the effort manually. Those are exactly the ones worth delegating.

### Procedural movement everywhere

Shaped automation is cheap to generate and tedious to draw. Put slow, differently-phased LFOs on six parameters across four tracks and the whole track breathes in a way that's very hard to achieve by hand.

> ***Try:*** *"Put slow sine automation on the filter cutoff of tracks 2, 3 and 5, each at a different cycle count so they drift against each other."*

**Uses:** `live_add_shaped_automation` · `live_read_device` · `live_read_param_range`

### Polyrhythm without the arithmetic

5-against-4 across three instruments with the phase relationship you actually want is an afternoon of counting. Or one sentence.

> ***Try:*** *"Write a 5-against-4 polyrhythm between the kick and hats, and put a 7-step Euclidean pattern on the percussion so all three phase against each other."*

**Uses:** `live_create_drum_pattern` · `live_generate_euclidean`

### Rhythm-locked automation

Volume automation shaped to follow the actual note positions of your kick pattern — real sidechain-style pumping without a compressor, precisely locked to the notes rather than approximated.

> ***Try:*** *"Read the kick pattern in track 1, then shape volume automation on track 3 that ducks exactly where those kicks land."*

**Uses:** `live_read_clip` · `live_add_shaped_automation`

### Classical transformations on modern material

Retrograde, inversion, augmentation — centuries-old techniques that are annoying to do by hand and often sound superb on electronic material.

> ***Try:*** *"Take my lead in track 5 and give me four variations in slots 2-5: retrograde, inverted, augmented, and inverted-retrograde."*

**Uses:** `live_transform_clip` · `live_read_clip`

## Closing the loop

The most genuinely novel capability here: Genius can change something, measure the actual audio result, and adjust based on what happened. Nothing else in this guide is as close to having an assistant.

### Tune to a target, automatically

Give it a measurable goal and let it iterate. Each pass costs real wall-clock time because the recording is real time, so cap the attempts — but the result is objectively verified rather than asserted.

> ***Try:*** *"Adjust the limiter until a 10-second capture measures between -15 and -13 LUFS. Maximum five attempts, and show me the number after each one."*

**Uses:** `live_record_and_analyze` · `live_update_device` · `live_read_param_range`

### Prove the tweak worked

Record before, make the change, record after, compare. It converts 'I think that helped' into a number.

> ***Try:*** *"Record 10 seconds, make the EQ change, record another 10, then tell me measurably what changed."*

**Uses:** `live_record_audio` · `live_update_device` · `live_compare_audio`

### The receipt pattern

Snapshot, do the risky thing, diff. Use it around anything you wouldn't want to reconstruct by hand — especially recipes, which change a lot at once.

> ***Try:*** *"Snapshot the session, apply the recipe, then diff it and list in plain English everything that changed."*

**Uses:** `live_session_snapshot` · `live_apply_recipe` · `live_session_diff`

### Structural prediction versus measured reality

Run the structural mix audit and a real recorded analysis, then look at where they disagree. The gap between what the Set looks like and what it measures is usually where the interesting problem is hiding.

> ***Try:*** *"Run a mix audit, then record 20 seconds and analyse it. Tell me where the two disagree and what you think that means."*

**Uses:** `live_analyze_mix` · `live_record_and_analyze` · `live_compare_audio`

## Performance and playability

Most Genius use is compositional, but the Session View tools make it a surprisingly good stage-prep assistant.

### Make a static Set performable

Launch modes, quantization and legato settings across dozens of clips is exactly the kind of consistent, boring configuration work that gets skipped.

> ***Try:*** *"Set every clip in scenes 1-4 to toggle mode with 1-bar quantization, and make the pad clips legato."*

**Uses:** `live_read_scene` · `live_set_clip_launch_mode` · `live_read_set`

### Build the breakdown versions

For every scene you have, create a stripped-back counterpart to drop into. Doing this by hand for eight scenes is an evening.

> ***Try:*** *"For each of scenes 1-4, create a stripped-back version in scenes 5-8 with the drums thinned out and the bass removed."*

**Uses:** `live_read_scene` · `live_create_scene` · `live_duplicate` · `live_remove_notes`

### Crossfader-ready staging

Assign tracks to crossfader sides by role so you can actually DJ between sections of your own track.

> ***Try:*** *"Put my drum and bass tracks on crossfader A, the melodic tracks on B, and centre the crossfader."*

**Uses:** `live_read_set` · `live_update_track` · `live_set_crossfader`

### Capture the happy accident

You improvise a good combination of clips and then lose it. One prompt freezes it permanently before it evaporates.

> ***Try:*** *"Capture whatever's playing right now into a new scene and name it."*

**Uses:** `live_create_scene` · `live_get_selected` · `live_update_scene`

# A suggested first session

If you have never used Genius for real work, this sequence gets you from nothing to a finished sketch while touching most of what matters. Expect it to take under an hour.

| # | Step | Prompt | Why |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Confirm the connection** | *“Connect to Ableton and tell me what you can see.”* | If this fails, fix it before anything else. Book 4 has the triage order. |
| 2 | **Set the foundation** | *“Set the tempo to 124 and the global scale to G minor.”* | Setting the scale makes everything generated later agree with Live's own scale awareness. |
| 3 | **Build the skeleton** | *“Make four MIDI tracks named Drums, Bass, Chords and Lead, each a different colour, and put a Drum Rack on Drums.”* | One sentence, roughly six actions. |
| 4 | **Get a beat down** | *“Read my drum rack, then write a 2-bar house beat using only pads that actually have samples loaded.”* | The read-first habit, immediately. Without it you get notes on empty pads. |
| 5 | **Add harmony** | *“Write a i–VI–III–VII progression in G minor on the Chords track, then a walking bass underneath it on Bass.”* | The bass has to read the chords first — let it. |
| 6 | **Make it move** | *“Put a slow sine filter sweep on the Chords track, one cycle per clip.”* | Procedural movement is the fastest cure for a static loop. |
| 7 | **Arrange it** | *“Build a 32-bar arrangement from these clips: 8 intro, 16 main, 8 outro, with locators.”* | Instant, not real time — this is copying, not recording. |
| 8 | **Check your work** | *“Audit the mix and tell me the three biggest problems. Don't fix anything yet.”* | Structural, not acoustic. Ask for the list before the fixes. |

### The thing most people get wrong

Treating Genius as a vending machine — one big request, one finished result. It is far better as a conversation: read, propose, adjust, commit. The prompts that fail are almost always the ones that asked for twelve things at once with no checkpoint in the middle.